

MEMO



Purpose

The focus of this research project is to show the need for moderation in censorship in regard to the way sensitive literature is taught in educational systems. This research will answer the main question of how one negotiates the teaching of sensitive literature. It will also address the following questions:

- To what extent should sensitive literature be censored based on age?
- What role does censorship play across religious, cultural, and ethnic groups?
- What impact does the teaching of sensitive literature have on the teacher and student respectively?

Background

I grew up in a household where there was a consistent focus on reading across different domains in literature. While my brothers and I have all taken different academic paths, all of us remain voracious readers. However, while we were encouraged to read a wide variety of books, there were always certain books or themes that we were encouraged not to read. The conversations about which books were censored from my home was a very open topic and well-debated, but it ultimately led to in-depth discussions on the nature of what constitutes a sensitive topic or theme in literature.

As I began my undergraduate education, I soon realized that while my family had definite ideas on what was “good” and needed to have in literature, I soon found that several individuals and families that I deeply respect feel very differently from myself in regard to sensitive literature. As I have read and become more aware to the different and heavier themes in literature, I have become grateful for the additional insights and capacity that those sensitive literature novels have given me both as a child and as an adult.

Significance

The topic of what is considered appropriate sensitive literature to teach and read is currently under heavy debate within both academia and educational spheres. While public educators traditionally feel very against censorship for sensitive subjects, many religious, political, and ethnic groups are actively pushing

back against what is being taught in schools and universities and advocating for higher forms of censorship. This has caused a harsh dichotomy surrounding sensitive literature. An individual is either for censorship and the right to not expose oneself to heavier topics and not have it forced upon them or the individual must be against censorship and feels that society at large will benefit from being exposed to those heavier themes. While both opinions are valid, neither give grace for the ground in between.

Description

This research project will cover firstly the conversations around censorship in educational systems in regards to sensitive literature. Secondly, the project will then focus on the differing opinions from other minority groups and their advocacy for and against censorship. Finally, the project will focus on the opinions of current college students on censorship and sensitive topics.

Basic Proposed Outline

- I. Rhetorical Situation
 - a. Explain the two stances
 - b. Impact it is having on students
 - c. Explain the difference between younger and older student groups
- II. Introduction
 - a. What does sensitive literature include?
 - b. Define sensitive literature and censorship
 - c. Advocate for finding the middle ground between the two
- III. Statements for Censorship of Sensitive Topics
 - a. Use Ginsberg and Moore articles
- IV. Statements Against Censorship of Sensitive Topics
 - a. Use Dobbs and Li articles
- V. Results From Student Polls
- VI. Conclusion
 - a. Need to reframe the censorship narrative
 - b. Involve students in the debate more

Annotated Bibliography

American Library Association. "Banned & Challenged Books." *American Library Association*, <https://www.ala.org/bbooks>. Accessed 13 May 2026. - This source provides the most commonly banned books by location as well as reasoning from educators on why they were banned.

Dobbs, Christina L., et al. "'Lots of Ways to Be Brave': A Teacher's Guide to Facing Censorship." *English Journal*, Jan. 2024. *Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson)*. - This source mainly focuses on the educator's perspective on teaching sensitive literature and how to stand up to opposition.

Ginsberg, Ricki, and Kyungae Chae. "National Report of Teachers' Experiences With School Justifications for Book Censorship." *Reading Research Quarterly*, July–Sept. 2025. *Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson)*. - This source focuses on statistical reports on censorship in the school system.

Johns, Brianna Rae. "Book Banning in US Schools and Prisons as Modern-Day Slave Codes." *English Journal*, Jan. 2024. *Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson)*. - This source compares old slave narratives to current news articles about book censorship.

Li, Rachel, et al. "'We Can't Be Sheltered': Why Banned Books Matter." *English Journal*, Jan. 2024. *Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson)*. - Of all the sources listed here, this source is the most strongly against censorship of sensitive information and advocates for making all book types readily available.

Lycke, Kara, and Thomas Lucey. "The Messages We Miss: Banned Books, Censored Texts, and Citizenship." *Journal of Social Studies Education Research*, 2018. *Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson)*. - This source argues that if sensitive literature is taken out of education that it will inhibit humanities' ability to relate and connect with one another.

Moore, Jennifer, and Alissa Tudor. "To Add or Not to Add: An Examination of Self-Censoring Behaviors among School Librarians." *School Library Research*, 2024. *Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson)*. - This source gives a comprehensive breakdown of how different educators choose to

censor what their students have access to. It also talks about what they feel their responsibilities are as educators.

National Council of Teachers of English. "Book Rationales." *NCTE*, <https://ncte.org/book-rationales/>. Accessed 13 May 2026. - This, like the ALA source, gives a breakdown of the different reasonings behind censoring commonly banned books. However, it tends to be the most unbiased of the banned book sourcing in this document.

PEN America. "Book Bans." *PEN America*, <https://pen.org/book-bans/>. Accessed 13 May 2026. - This source actively promotes avoiding censorship and details how different groups are opposing censorship across the United States.

Shanks, Liz. "Teaching Challenged Books Through a Lens of Censorship." *Virginia English Journal*, Fall 2024. *Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson)*. - This source gives a more intimate view of the impact of censorship for individuals and the personal effect of censorship in educational spheres.

Timetable and Schedule

Stage	Date	Status
Research	May 18	Completed
Finish Sourcing	May 20	In Progress
Outline	May 21	In Progress
Rough Draft	May 23	Not Begun
Finish Rough Draft	May 29	Not Begun
Peer Review	June 3	Not Begun
Revisions	June 4	Not Begun
Final Draft	June 4	Not Begun
Submission	June 5	Not Begun

Request for Approval

This project will enable both students and educators to come into the discussion of censorship of sensitive literature with a more well-rounded perspective. I hope that it will provide readers with the ability and capacity to both understand more clearly why some topics are highly debated and why different groups of people feel the need for different censorship standards. I respectfully request permission to complete this research project.